

Berkeley: *Second Dialogue*

January 20th, 2004

‘Scepticism’ and idealism

- In Berkeley’s usage, a sceptic denies the ‘real existence’ of sensible things.
- To reconcile the claim that there are no material objects with the claim that there really are sensible things, we must maintain that sensible things are immaterial.
 - Ideas — or bundles of ideas.

God

- A new argument for the existence of God (p. 97):
 - Sensible things can exist even when no finite mind perceives them. But sensible things cannot exist when no mind perceives them. Therefore, there is an infinite mind.
- God and his ideas are going to play a crucial role in Berkeley's account of how common sense claims (e.g. those in the 'purple passage' on p. 96-97) get to be true.

There once was a man who said, “God
Must think it exceedingly odd
If He finds that this tree
Continues to be
When there’s no one about in the Quad.”

“Dear Sir:

 Your astonishment’s odd:
I am always about in the Quad
And that’s why the tree
Will continue to be,
Since observed by,
 Yours faithfully,
 God.”

- Berkeley seems to be neutral between two accounts of the relation between God's ideas and ours:
 - (i) God's ideas are *archetypes* of which ours are *copies*.
 - (ii) God's ideas are numerically identical to ours.
- What is the world of God's ideas like? Does he have equally vivid ideas of all possible sensible things, including golden mountains, unicorns, etc., as well as tables and chairs?

Matter as lacking sensible qualities?

- The target in the *First Dialogue* is the view that material objects exist, and have at least some of the sensible qualities (e.g. shape) of which we are immediately aware.
- In the *Second Dialogue*, Berkeley considers the view that material objects exist but don't share any of the qualities we are aware of our sensations as having.

- Given Berkeley's premise that words like 'colour', 'shape', 'extension', 'motion'... stand for qualities of which we are immediately aware, this view implies that matter is colourless, shapeless, unextended, motionless...
 - Which certainly sounds bizarre.
 - It's contradictory, if 'matter' just *means* 'extended, solid, moveable, unthinking, inactive substance', as Berkeley holds (p101). (NB: this isn't his only argument!)
 - But if we had a different view about the meanings of these words, it wouldn't have to *sound* so bad.

The argument from Ockham's razor

- 'Entities should not be multiplied without necessity'
 - 'It is to me a sufficient reason not to believe the existence of any thing, if I see no reason for believing it' (103)
- Since we already need God to explain where our sensations come from, matter adds nothing to the explanation.
 - This is backed up by the next line of argument...

The causal argument

- The proponent of the view (Hylas) is challenged to say how material objects relate to our sensations. Possible answers:
 1. They cause them (101)
 2. They are *instruments* God uses to produce them (102)
 3. They are *occasions* at which God chooses to produce them (104)
 4. None of the above (106)

- Against answer 1 ('they cause them'):
 - 'How can that which is *inactive* be a *cause*; or that which is *unthinking* be a *cause of thought*'? (101)
 - By motion?
 - But we've already shown that matter doesn't move, since motion is a sensible quality.
 - In any case, motion doesn't confer any sort of action, as we see from our sensations which sometimes have motion but are all inactive.

- Against answer 2 (‘They are *instruments* God uses to produce them’)
 - A perfect, omnipotent being would have no need of instruments, since he can do anything he wants directly.
- Against answer 3 (‘Occasions’ — c.f. Malebranche)
 - It ‘derogates’ from God’s wisdom and power to suppose he is put in mind when to act by unthinking substances.
 - In any case, the true ‘occasions’ are the *ideas* whereby God is supposed to be aware of matter.

- A possible further argument: such things are *inconceivable*, hence they don't exist. The hypothesis is really meaningless.
 - The only *ideas* we can form are ideas of things with the qualities we are aware of in sensory experience.
 - (A basic *empiricist* tenet—Descartes wouldn't agree!)
 - But can't we imagine *that there is some quality other than those we are aware of* without having to imagine any *specific* such quality? (C.f. my critique of the Master Argument).

- Against answer 4 (‘None of the above’)
 - A hypothesis is meaningful only if we can attach some idea (or ‘notion’) to it.
 - We have no notion at all to associate with a purely negative version of the matter hypothesis. (Not even a ‘relative notion’: 108)
 - But can’t we imagine *that there is some quality or other distinct from those we are aware of* without imagining any *specific* such quality? (C.f. my critique of the Master Argument).

- Russell's view (www.ditext.com/russell)
 - Material objects have none of the qualities we are aware of ('acquainted with', in Russell's terminology)
 - But we can form hypotheses along the following lines:
'there are 17 qualities and 5 relations distinct from all those with which we are acquainted, and whenever something that has quality 1 bears relation 3 to something with quality 12, it has quality 15, ... and there is something such that whenever it bears relation 5 to something with quality 17, I feel pain...'
 - Note: Russell was happy to speak of material objects as causing our sensations.